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THE HINDU



Readers get nostalgic as British Council's Anna Salai library closes down **P2**

WHY SEMMALAR ANAM IS PROUD OF MAYILAA **P4**

As new pickleball courts open across Chennai, the sport is doing more than just filling evening slots — it is creating WhatsApp communities, business networks and unlikely friendships



Picklers unite (Left to right) Manav Subramanian, Siddharth Sekhar, and Varun Prashant - founders of Serv; (below) players get together for a snack after a game at Winkin ALM. B VELANKANNI RAJ AND JOHAN SATHYADAS

Hasnain Kapadia, a self-confessed introvert. "Once I started playing at Winkin, my friends' circle grew," he says. Evenings spent playing video games at home have been replaced with competitive matches and dinner with fellow picklers. There is even a trip to Bengaluru in the works, where the group plans to play, eat, and chill.

Chennai is now criss-crossed by Pickleball WhatsApp groups, where members decide when to play, and where to meet afterwards — for a meal, a movie, or even a weekend getaway. It has never been easier to make friends in a city often described as reserved.

With easily 40 to 100 people in these groups, there is always someone to pick up the paddle and rally with. "It's great for building contacts, and in my case, it also helped with my business as I met potential clients here," adds Shanmugaraj, who co-owns Winkin courts across the city including at Injambakkam and Anna Nagar. The next one is coming up in Neelankarai where Cafe Trotter will brew coffee. "We want to set up courts in every area. The idea is, if you are part of Winkin, you should be able to play anywhere," he says.

When 23-year-old Sanu Raghav moved from Coimbatore to Chennai for work, he said it was difficult to make friends. "Chennai wasn't completely new to me, but starting fresh as a working professional is very different from being a student. Social circles are already formed. There was definitely a sense of loneliness," he says.

Soon, Sanu took up pickleball. "Once I started playing regularly, conversations happened naturally. There was no pressure, just people meeting over a shared interest. I formed genuine friendships," he says. "There's a feeling of belonging, of being accepted for who you are. Over time, it genuinely began to feel like a second family."



In a pickle, and loving it

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The game brought them close. Pickleball WhatsApp groups brought them closer.

Vikram Chandrasekar, co-owner, Baseline, Chennai's latest pickleball facility, says that when he was going through a rough patch, his pickleball community was his support system. Little acts of kindness like bringing him food, or just confiding in them made a difference. "At 50, it's hard to make friends, but I made some really great ones through pickleball," says Vikram.

"The sport is very social, so the idea was to see if we could build something that could fit into people's lives. Not just a court rental space, but somewhere families could come and hang. That's why we decided to have the Gobbelin cafe and a co-working space," Vikram says, adding that hospitality and community can co-exist around sport as an anchor. "People come here, set up their laptops to work.

They take a break in between, play a game or two and get back to work."

Baseline, in Gandhi Nagar, follows a membership model, different from the pay as you play concept that most courts offer. It comprises three tournament grade courts, a store for equipment, and a viewing deck/fitness area on the first floor. A group of women are at play, the oldest of whom is 73 years. There is a little lawn on the outside. "I want to use this space to host community events like Sunday markets, pickleball mixers, brunch," says Vikram.

Rallying around

At Serv, T Nagar, three 28-year-olds are at the helm of things. Best friends and now business partners — Varun Prashant, Siddharth Sekhar, and Manav Subramanian — initially planned to start a cloud kitchen.

Then, they discovered pickleball.

From six people booking on the day of launch in December 2025, they saw the numbers rise to 43 bookings a day, in no time. By the end of the month, Serv will launch Bold cafe in partnership with restaurateur Sandesh Reddy.

"Our vision was to have a premium facility with a community-first approach. A place where people come together for sports, recovery or wellness. The recovery room will have an ice bath, sauna, a stretching area, and massage guns. At Bold, you can have a clean nutritious meal after a game and wrap up your day. This is a social wellness brand and we wish to take it across the State," says Varun. There are four pickleball courts here and one padel court. "We are open till midnight and once the cafe comes up we will try to keep the facility open till 2am," he adds. They

also plan to host events for the community. Think: singles events, mixed doubles tournaments, yoga day, live music.

"Our customers are recurring ones. Certain groups come everyday. People come with their kids and families. This has become a hangout," says Siddharth, pleased with the development. The bulk of the players at Serv are in the 20-40 age bracket. These include novices, intermediates, and professionals.

The reason that pickleball is so popular, Manav believes is because the entry barrier is low. "It's less technical than other racket sports, easier to pick up. A lot of people want to be part of a larger community. Pickleball fits in well. It's a new sport so no one really has a massive advantage of having played for a longer period. As a

group you move together to an intermediate stage. That learning curve brings people together," believes Manav.

Dink, bond, laugh

To build this community further, many courts are planned with cafes and co-working spaces attached. The growing list includes Pickle & Chill and Crafe in Anna Nagar, Serv in T Nagar, Baseline in Gandhi Nagar, Madras Blend & Brews in Purusaiwalkam...

Shamugaraj Thangaraj, perhaps one of the earliest to start this trend with Egco-Winkin in Anna Nagar last March, almost feels like a proud parent as he watches different people from different walks come together to play, forming bonds that continue well beyond the courts.

"Pickleball made me social," says

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As TV Mohan was heading towards the transit gate at Doha International Airport recently, a couple stopped him. A baby in her arms and a smile on her face, the young mother bent down to seek Mohan's blessings.

"Do you remember us?" she asked, gesturing towards her husband. "We got married because of you. And this is our baby."

Mohan smiled, visibly moved. Encounters like this are almost routine for him — at cultural events and wedding halls.

Long before Sima Aunty and today's algorithm-driven matchmakers entered popular culture, there was 'Kalyanamalai' Mohan. Since 2000, his appearances on *Kalyanamalai*, Sun TV's matchmaking show, have brought him widespread recognition. Over more than 1,200 episodes, Mohan has conversed with hopeful alliance seekers, positioning himself as a bridge between prospective brides and grooms. Today, after 26 years in the field, *Kalyanamalai* has facilitated over 6.5 lakh weddings.

You've got mail

Hailing from Thiruvurur district, Mohan vividly recalls the



The OG matchmaker

With February widely celebrated as the season of love, popular veteran matchmaker 'Kalyanamalai' Mohan reflects on playing Cupid for over 25 years

Those were the years when decisions were largely driven by parents and relatives. "Gradually, as education and employment opportunities opened up for both men and women, families began to

realise that relatives were no longer central to the decision-making process," he says. It was around this shift that the idea of *Kalyanamalai* took shape. "The matrimonial section of *The Hindu* was hugely

The bride side 'Kalyanamalai' Mohan.
JOHAN SATHYADAS

popular — sometimes running over four pages. Every Sunday, parents would buy a copy and pore over the listings."

What if that same exercise could unfold on television, he wondered. That question eventually gave birth to *Kalyanamalai* as a concept.

Knot happening

Despite spending over 25 years in the field and witnessing sweeping technological change, *Kalyanamalai* and Mohan have endured. So what, according to him, is the secret to this longevity? "Even as we adapt to changing attitudes towards marriage, we take pride in finding the *right* person for each search. Some platforms bombard people with multiple profiles, but we first understand the requirement, without judgement, and then suggest a few names. In some cases, we have recommended just one person, and a marriage has followed," he says.

Mohan believes that an excess of choice has become a major obstacle in today's matchmaking process. For him, occasions such as Valentine's Day are less about grand gestures and more about decisions that last a lifetime. "Young people today swipe through profiles as though they are

shopping for saris or vegetables. Marriage cannot be decided this way; it concerns the rest of your life. An alliance seeker must also accept that not every expectation will be met. I believe a few meetings are enough to make a decision — beyond that, people begin focussing on what they don't want rather than what they hope for."

Now 74, Mohan observes a marked shift in attitudes towards marriage. "Parents today are often hesitant to even raise the subject with their children. Many ask me, 'How do I approach my son or daughter about this?' That parents feel this anxiety is worrying. All they want, ultimately, is for their children to live peaceful lives."

He recalls discussing this at length with the late former President APJ Abdul Kalam, a conversation he counts among the most meaningful of his life. "Do you know what he told me?" Mohan says. "He said we are not merely matching a boy and a girl, but setting future generations in motion for every family. Those words still ring in my ears."



To watch video interview, scan QR code

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Long empty shelves that once transported a million people of Chennai to a billion worlds stand erect in time. The halls that once sang the quiet melody of a declining art now look like empty structures. The British Council Library in Chennai, an iconic landmark that academics, scholars, students, and other literati thronged to over the decades, is bidding adieu to its physical form as part of the UK organisation's move to digitalise its services.

Janaka Pushpanathan, director South India, British Council, says the transition is to ensure resources are used where they can make the greatest difference. "In recent years, audience expectations around flexibility and access have shifted strongly towards digital platforms. Globally, over 1,60,000 members use our digital library resources, and in India, 50,000 members across 190-plus cities and 23 states now access services online, allowing us to reach far beyond metro centres," she adds.

It is not just the library that will be missed; the British Council, which was established in Madras in 1948, will vacate its 737 Anna Salai premises by March, with operations moving online until it relocates to a new space.

When I met him at the library, CS Venkataramanan stood at the entrance, hands to his hips, studying the empty hall that once held his evenings, as if waiting for



The end of the aisles

With the British Council Library in Chennai, a cherished cultural and academic hub since 1948, closing its physical doors, longtime visitors reflect on the profound impact the space has had on their lives

End of an era (Left) The British Council Library in Chennai on February 10, 2010; Susheela Kumar, chief librarian, on January 22, 1980. THANTHONI S AND THE HINDU ARCHIVES

the library to recognise him. "I am coming here after 10 years, and all the memories from the old days are flashing through my mind. In the evenings, after office, and sometimes, even before shift hours, I would come here," says the 68-year-old retired Assistant Commissioner, Ministry of Finance. Venkataramanan first visited the library in 1980, when he was working as an auditor in the city. "The digital boom hadn't happened. There were only physical books available. The library had a different atmosphere back then, and it wasn't as big," he reminisces.

The library has young fans, too. Vanathi Panneerselvam, a 26-year-old lawyer, first visited the library for the British Council's English as a Secondary Language course. "We would be brought here to give our exams. The space had this old-world charm, even back when I was 13-14 years old; it had a payphone that I would use to call my parents to come and pick me up after my session."

What truly sets the library apart, Janaka says, is the trust that readers like Vanathi and Venkataramanan place in it. "For decades, readers knew they would find thoughtfully curated, high-quality UK and international content, from contemporary literature and academic resources to language

learning material – all in one place."

Twenty-four-year-old Prasanna Venkatesh recollects the times he used to spend at the lawn outside the library or the cafeteria after the classes he attended as part of a summer programme. "To find a place like that in the city is rare... somewhere you can get some calm. It's almost a separate world by itself."

Venkataramanan, a voracious reader, used to read thrillers of authors like Frederick Forsyth and John le Carré, motivational books and spiritual guides at the library. However, he particularly misses the library's newspaper collections. "I was predominantly interested in catching up on what's on the political front. Besides local newspapers, I used to read international newspapers. Those newspapers used to have some 100 pages back then."

Vanathi remembers picking up one of her first novels, *Treasure Island* by Robert Louis Stevenson, at the library when she was 12 or 13. "But the library actually had a brilliant *Reader's Digest* collection, and I

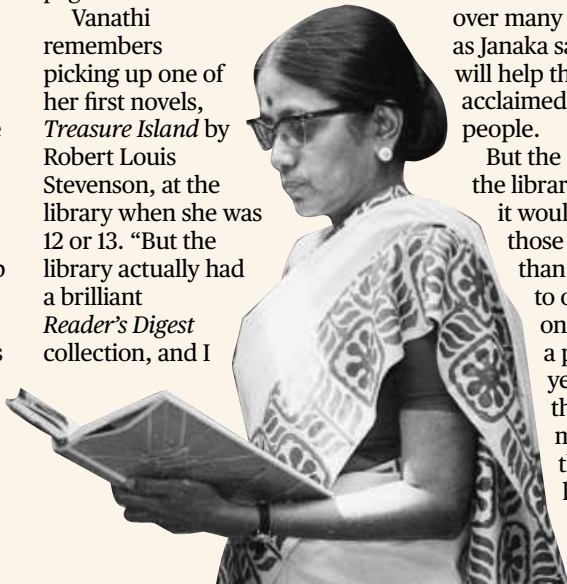
remember reading those."

Janaka says that the library was initially popular for medical and engineering book collections from the UK. "As reading habits and access models evolved, our focus expanded to contemporary arts, literature, culture and interdisciplinary thinking."

Now that the physical library is coming to a close, Prasanna wishes he had spent more time there. "To lose a place that is an integral part of my childhood does feel bitter. It was a place where I met people with different values. So that was like an opening into another world for me. It will always remain special."

"The messages and memories everyone has shared are deeply moving," reflects Janaka, adding that these responses speak for the long-standing relationship the British Council has built with communities across South India over many decades. It is true that, as Janaka says, the shift to digital will help the organisation take its acclaimed library services to more people.

But the fact remains that while the library will continue to exist, it would not be the same to those who have gained more than just what the books had to offer – memories, the ones that are deeply tied to a place. And in the 78 years since its inception, these walls have seen more smiles and tears than you and I could in a lifetime. For that and more, we bid our goodbye.



Redwood fair returns

The Redwood Foundation will host the 11th edition of the Organic Fair with a renewed focus on promoting healthy lifestyle and mindful living. The initiative aims to create awareness about homemade, sustainable, eco-friendly and organic choices in everyday life, says Madhura Visveswaran, founder, Redwood Montessori School.

To encourage young entrepreneurs, the students of Redwood Montessori School, Sri Sankara Senior Secondary School, Adyar, and KSN Senior Secondary School, Thiruvannamiyur, will present their handmade eco-friendly candles and soaps, baskets and other utility products," says Madhura.

Madhura says that this year she has invited NGOs such as Naam Foundation and Hastha, who will showcase their handcrafted products at the



fair. "To encourage children to shop for fresh organic vegetables and fruits, we have My Harvest Farms and Sembak Farm, who will set up a market place at the fair," she says. Visitors can shop for chutney powders, jams and pickles, honey, cheese, baked goodies and more.

@Redwood Montessori School, Teynampet, February 21, 3.30pm to 6.30pm. Call 9789821794.

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Radhika Menon can never forget the moment she held the first Tulika book in 1996. "It was literally hot off the press because we were at the printing press in Kilpauk," she recalls. In its previous avatar, Tulika was a prepress services unit in Delhi, doing work for other publishers and organisations. "Somewhere in our mind, we knew that we would one day publish our own books," she says.

Their first office was near the Music College atop a screen-printing unit and with a small team of three, Radhika started the publishing house that would go on to bring out children's books in nine languages. For Radhika, who has had experience in teaching in Chennai and Delhi, getting into publishing "was a natural coming together of my interests and experiences".

Their first book, *Line and Circle* was a bilingual, a format that was not accepted in the Indian market back then, especially schools. "They were not used to having another language in the same book," she recalls. But to her and her team, it was a natural way to introduce children to reading. While they struggled to sell it in India, they sold rights for over 20 languages in the first year.

"But we never lacked confidence; we were convinced that these books were needed," she says. After a lot of struggle – during which they brought out theme-based diaries to keep themselves afloat – Radhika recalls the market opening up from 2010. They have so far published around 450 titles in English; with over 3,000 inclusive of eight other languages, working with 176 authors, 150 illustrators and 120 translators.

Tulika brought in some refreshing changes to children's books. It focussed on an Indian setting with relatable characters. Its women also dressed in saris and salwars and



Pages in history (Left) Tulika Store at TTK Road; (below) Radhika Menon, founder, Tulika. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

how far the 'gentle elephant' has come. "We had never anticipated it or planned for a series. It was the children's responses that inspired Ashok and that led us from one book to the next! The series took on a momentum of its own."

Over these years, Radhika has worked with some exceptional minds, this includes their most-loved authors such as Sandhya Rao, writer and illustrator Manjula Padmanabhan, illustrators Proiti Roy and Sandhya Prabhat. Radhika feels publishing "is no longer about conceptualising, editing, designing books but about events and promotions," adding that it is not just about the printed book in bookstores and libraries but about online presence. "And there the possibilities and opportunities are endless and constantly evolving," she says.

Now that she has spent 30 years as a publisher, she too has evolved. Her work, she says has made her "patient, reflective and more conscious of the responsibility we carry when creating for young minds." She is constantly looking for ideas: from conversations, films, books, articles, and podcasts. "But translating those ideas into an imaginative, fully realised children's book is a daunting challenge," she says.

Radhika adds: "Over recent years, there is anxiety about the world children are growing up in. As a publisher, grandmother, teacher, I see children's books as offering hope: by creating a sense and sensibility that gives them tools and skills to deal with the world in a subliminal way. A good children's book is a safe space. A source of comfort, emotional support."

The bookmaker and her dream



As Chennai-based children's publishing house Tulika turned 30 earlier this month, its founder Radhika Menon talks about her journey bringing out over 3,000 books in nine languages, and counting

sported *kondais*; there are several dhoti and lungi-clad men in their pages, with characters shown as dark-skinned, everyday people one would encounter in our streets. This was possible because of their illustrators.

Among their popular titles are the Gajapati Kulapati books by Ashok Rajagopalan. "Ashok first wrote it as a fun thing for a story-telling session; I said let's make a book out of it," recalls Radhika. Today, it is the first book for many children, and she is amazed at

Weaving time and space

In Tribute to My Father, textile artist Kalyani Pramod reinterprets photographs by the late photojournalist TS Nagarajan through thread

Canvas of memory Art by Kalyani Pramod. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



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When I walk into textile artist Kalyani Pramod's Chennai studio, she is sipping tea, surrounded by framed textile and paper works. They are ready to be packed and sent to Lalit Kala Akademi, the venue for her ongoing exhibition, *Tribute to My Father*, a personal homage to her father, the late photojournalist TS Nagarajan.

From the age of seven, she travelled across the country with her father, accompanying him to exhibitions and on assignments that placed her inside a world of photographers, dancers and artists. "I think I've become a designer because of him and his friends. We had artists of different kinds coming home, and it opened to me a new world," she says. For the exhibition, she has selected a few of her father's photographs from the negatives she has preserved. Displayed alongside each image are her textile and paper interpretations – woven tapestries, miniature embroideries and delicate

works on tea-stained paper. In total, 82 pieces are on display.

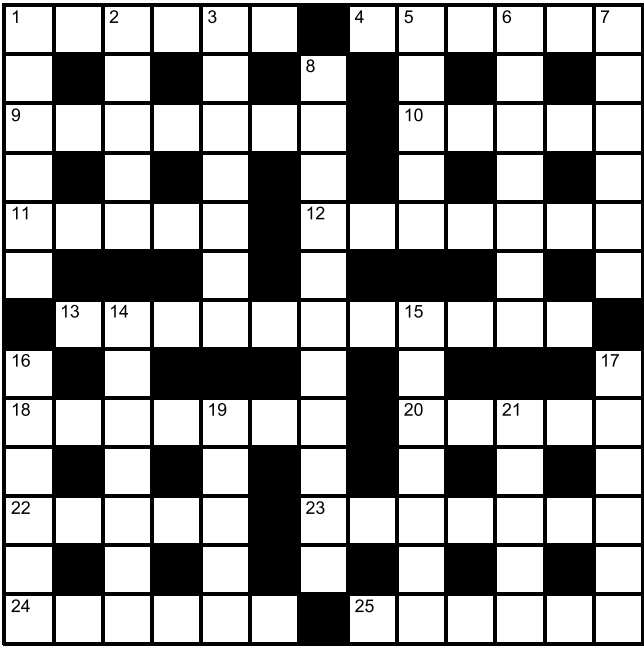
Among the works are woven tapestries in silk and wool, miniature black-and-white embroideries and portraits stitched onto used tea bags. They are opened and repurposed as canvas. Using tea bags is also her way of repurposing waste. An advocate of working with discarded material, Kalyani often collects what others throw away.

Alongside the pieces drawn directly from her father's photographs is a separate series titled *Banaras*. These are not based on his images but on her own visual memory of the city. "My father would take us to Varanasi because he was doing features on the city, and I have vivid memories from my time there," she says.

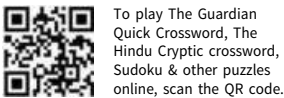
For an artist who has long used her practice to foreground larger concerns, from climate change to endangered species, *Tribute to My Father* is both intimate and expansive.

Tribute to My Father is on display at Lalit Kala Akademi until February 26.

QUICK CROSSWORD #41 (Set by Doppelganger)

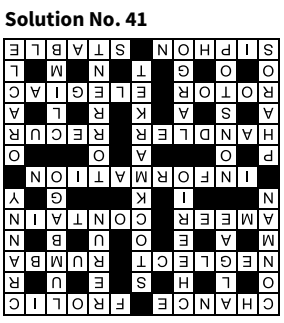


- Across**
- 1 Opportunity (6)
 - 4 Playful behaviour (6)
 - 9 Leave undone (7)
 - 10 Afro-Cuban dance (5)
 - 11 Muslim ruler (5)
 - 12 Control (7)
 - 13 Knowledge gained (11)
 - 18 Trainer (7)
 - 20 Happen again (5)
 - 22 Part of helicopter (5)
 - 23 Mournful (7)
 - 24 Liquid transferring device (6)
 - 25 Constant (6)
- Down**
- 1 Swindler (3,3)
 - 2 Multicellular seaweed (5)
 - 3 Bye-bye (7)
 - 5 Repeat (5)
 - 6 Back pain (7)
 - 7 Narrow opening (6)
 - 8 Securities exchange (5,6)



To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.

- 14 Endless (7)
- 15 Flood (7)
- 16 Site of ancient lighthouse (6)
- 17 He can prophecy the future (6)
- 19 Slow and dignified (5)
- 21 Mount (5)





Fervour and fandom Chennai's cosplayers from Comic Con 2026.
JOHAN SATHYADAS

also spotlighted Indian comic artists who have spent years crafting original and culturally rich narratives. Savio Mascarenhas, group art director, Amar Chitra Katha and Tinkle Studios, was present at the event and expressed his delight at the overwhelming crowd. From co-creating Suppandi and illustrating characters such as Shikhari Shambhu, he dived into the world of how these Indian comics have played a strong role in shaping childhood since the 1980s. "Our primary audience consists of readers who grew up with these comics, many of whom are now in their forties. They share a deep emotional connection with the books and often recreate that nostalgia by introducing them to their own children," says Savio. Vivek Goel, founder, Holy Cow Entertainment and an Indian comic book artist, showed up displaying several of his comic books. As the founder of an independent comic book publishing house, he spoke about the growing comic book community in India.

"My books have a deep cultural and religious impact. From childhood, we grew up listening to stories from the Ramayana and the Mahabharata, and their characters leave a lasting impression on us. Portraying them as more than mere figures from mythology has allowed me to merge visual storytelling with a rich cultural framework," says Vivek. Comic Con 2026 showcased how fandom in the city is becoming more confident, collaborative and creatively ambitious.

Cosplay central

Over 500 fans transformed Chennai Trade Centre into a living multiverse

Kamalika Chatterjee and Priyamedha Dutta
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A riot of capes, corsets, and carefully crafted armour took centrestage as Chennai Comic Con wrapped up on February 14 and 15 at the Chennai Trade Centre, with cosplay emerging as the undisputed showstopper. From anime icons and gaming legends to beloved Indian comic characters, over 500 fans transformed the venue into a living, breathing multiverse, showcasing how Chennai's fandom culture has evolved, placing the city on India's pop culture map. "It's my first Comic Con, and the atmosphere is pretty welcoming," said Om Tiwari, dressed as Stein from *Soul Eater*, adjusting the handmade scythe that he built over six hours using cardboard and cans. "Earlier, you didn't always find people you could openly talk to about anime. But here, everyone just gets it – the vibe, the

characters. My aim for next year is to be back as a better cosplayer," he added.

In the crowd of anime characters, we spotted 31-year-old IT professional Vignesh dressed as a Second World War paratrooper that took him 10 months to create. "I started right after the last Comic Con. The jacket is completely hand-stitched. The rifle – an M1, the standard-issue weapon for an average infantryman during WWII is fully hand-printed, which I assembled and painted by hand. The helmet is made of foam, and even the patches are hand-embroidered." For him, the effort is inseparable from the platform. "I wouldn't be doing it if not for Comic Con. It gives a lot of volume to what we create."

The event brought together comic book artists from across industries, creating a vibrant space for fans to connect and celebrate their love for comics. Along with global comic companies, the event



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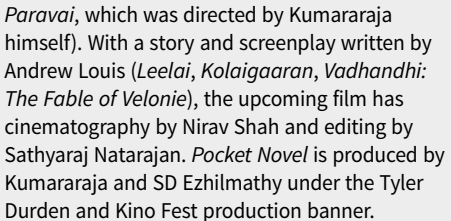


Music composer and performer Anirudh Ravichander has announced the launch of his own artist-owned music label, Albuquerque Record. The label is positioned as a platform for both film and non-film music. With Albuquerque Records, he moves beyond composing and performing into long-term music ownership. The label will initially house select original soundtracks from Anirudh's upcoming film projects, alongside all his independent pop releases, while also introducing new artists and voices within the regional pop space. Alongside the label announcement, Anirudh also revealed plans for a large-scale concert tour titled *Rockstar Anirudh XV: 15 Years With You*, celebrating 15 years of his music career. The tour will open in Hyderabad on March 21, 2026, at the Gachibowli Outdoor Stadium, marking his first-ever live concert in the city. The tour follows the success of Anirudh's previous *Hukum Tour*, which drew record-breaking crowds.

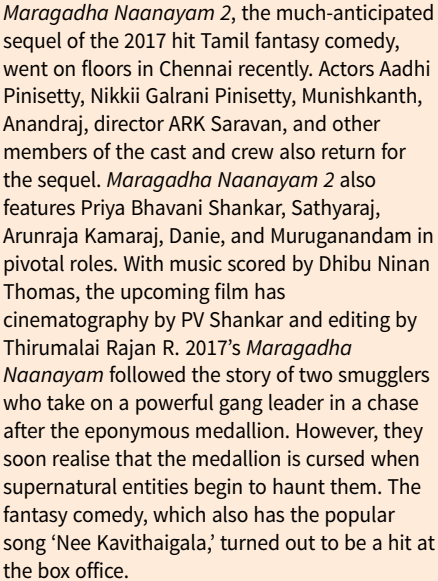
A spectacle beckons

Tamil star Sivakarthikeyan is all set to star in an upcoming film titled *Seyon*. Directed by Sivakumar Murugesan (whose *Thaai Kizhavi* is set to release soon, the upcoming film is produced by Kamal Haasan under his Raaj Kamal Films International production banner, marking a reunion between the actor and producer after their hit 2024 film *Amaran*. “*Seyon* is set to be the biggest family spectacle of 2026, blending rooted emotions, mass appeal, and wholesome entertainment for audiences across generations,” reads a press release from the makers. With music scored by Santhosh Narayanan, the film has cinematography by Vivek Vijayakumar and editing by San Lokesh. Kamal produces the film along with M Mahendran. Notably, Kamal’s Raaj Kamal Films International is also bankrolling *Thalaivar 173*, starring Rajinikanth and directed by Cibi Chakravarthy, and Kamal’s *KH 237*, directed by Anbarivu.

Acclaimed Tamil filmmaker Thiagarajan Kumararaja has reunited with his *Super Deluxe* star Vijay Sethupathi for his upcoming film, *Pocket Novel*. The film, also starring Kannada star Raj B Shetty, Kishore and Malavika Mohanan, marks Kumararaja's return to feature film direction after seven long years. Notably,



The chase is on



Prathap Nair

Semmalar Annam's first love has always been film direction, even though it took a backseat since acting kept her busy all these years. But along came a blessing in disguise – the COVID-19 pandemic-induced lockdown in 2020 – as it gifted her ample time to work on the script she had in mind.

Annam says she started working with a string of situations – a young mother in an abusive relationship and her constipated daughter. It gradually grew into an endearing film about the quiet resilience of a mother-daughter duo, which she has just shown at the International Film Festival Rotterdam (IFFR) and was warmly received by a global audience.

Mayilaa, produced by Newton Cinemas and presented by Pa Ranjith, is drawn from a composite of real-life anecdotes, with the titular character a reimagination of her own grandmother's life. "My grandmother was in her



■ A Journalism and Mass Communication graduate from PSG College of Arts and Science, Semmalar hails from Coimbatore. She studied Acting at Stanislavsky Acting School in Chennai and has also been a part of Koothu-P-Pattarai.

■ She won the Rising Star Emerging Actress Award at the Toronto Tamil International Film Festival 2021 for her performance in *Sennai*.

■ Her directorial, *Mayilaa*, is inspired by her grandmother's life.

Social commentary

Semmalar Annam; (below) with Vinoth Janakiraman, Melody Dorcas, Shudar Kodi, Stefan Borsos, and producer Anto Chittilappilly at Rotterdam.

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Bhagyaraj and Mahendran," Annam confesses. "But also, commercially successful ones like KS Ravikumar."

The film follows Mayilaa, a young woman with a daughter, stuck in a cycle of domestic abuse and crushing poverty. Mayilaa is a day labourer, and her job involves sifting toxic sand for metal scraps. When she finds herself cornered with multiple crises – unemployment, an alcoholic husband who doesn't provide for the family, and financial needs to preside over the festivities of the neighbourhood Amman temple – she takes up a job as a travelling saleswoman of grass mats. Amid all this, Mayilaa's daughter Sudar's (played by Shudhar Kodil) constipation runs as a metaphorical thread connecting the multiple levels of toxicity stifling her.

On her trip, she meets toxic men and resilient women, rich people who invite her into their homes and poor people who guard those rich homes and deny her access. It is a kaleidoscope of biting social commentary told through a starkly realist lens. Mayilaa finds camaraderie in a welcoming sisterhood and their safe spaces, which men have no access to.

Annam says women would open up to her when she travelled to rural regions for her film shoots. Often, they expressed a sense of surprise that she is allowed such freedom by her husband to leave her daughter and travel for work. In a way, *Mayilaa* is also Annam's quest to understand what makes women stay in abusive relationships. "Shockingly, even many of my educated friends are stuck in unhappy, even abusive marriages with no respite. I wanted *Mayilaa* to embody all those women," she says.

Melody Dorcas, who plays Mayilaa, was a choice Annam had no difficulty making. Dorcas portrays Mayilaa with a commitment that led some audience members in the Q&A session at the IFFR to question whether the actors in the film are all actual people from a village. Which, to be fair, most are, according to Annam. “I have worked with Melody in *Appatha*, and I needed a strong performer,” Annam says.

Annam is determined to release *Mayilaa* in Indian theatres on Women's Day on March 8. With less than a month left, the team is now gearing up to finish the remaining post-production work and send the film to the Censor Board so as not miss the release day target. "If not Women's Day, I want the film to release at least in the month of March," she adds.

Actors Rahul Bhatt and Sunny Leone open up on essaying complex characters in Anurag Kashyap's film, set to stream on ZEE5 this week

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It's not an Anurag Kashyap film if it doesn't face a release delay. The filmmaker has battled distribution hurdles and censorship delays for years with a mix of candid and provocative approaches. His film, *Kennedy*, is set for a mainstream release three years after its 2023 Cannes premiere. It has travelled the world, participating in significant festivals. Now, the audience in India can finally catch the neo-noir crime thriller.

“Of course, there was some anxiety,” actor Rahul Bhat tells *The Hindu* about the long wait for the movie’s worldwide release. “However, it’s stayed alive due to festivals.” Bhat’s co-star, Sunny Leone, is excited as well for the movie’s upcoming OTT premiere. “I was reminded over and over again that every film will find its home, and I am very excited that this film has found one. I am excited, and no longer feel bad about the delay.”

The world of *Kennedy* is set in Kashyap's trademark zone: raw and unapologetic. The thriller, set to drop on ZEE5 on February 20, highlights the systematic corruption of the Mumbai police and jolts you with the consequences of the normalisation of murder.

At the centre of the gritty story is Uday Shetty aka Kennedy, a former cop-turned-hitman essayed by Bhat. It is the pandemic in India, and Uday, mostly covered in a mask, shows no remorse as he displays qualities of a near-perfect hired killer. Look closely, and you sense the troubled past of the protagonist. Bhat calls playing an emotionally distant character an “internal performance”. “Kennedy carries the trauma in his body. It’s in his walk, gaze, and stillness. Once I

got into the headspace of the character, it was hard to step out of it. The movie reflects a nocturnal, decaying space. It shows what happens when survival becomes a moral compromise," says the actor.

Sunny plays Charlie, a mysterious character with unique traits. Charlie's peculiar laugh adds to the enigma around her. "Anurag gave me references for the laugh. I had to make it part of my personality. I was shooting a song with 150 dancers and another 100 crew members. I practised the laugh in the middle of the shoot. I told myself that if I can laugh in one of the most uncomfortable places to try something like that, then I can deliver on the sets of *Kennedy* easily. I took the laugh everywhere, to airports, cars, and meetings," recollects the actor.

Kennedy is marked by realistic action sequences. Bhat finds stunts in Kashyap's films far from the usual. "He strips glamour off the action. The camera is always close and unforgiving during an action sequence in a Kashyap movie. You must match the hand-held energy of the camera by reacting to it rather than performing in a staged manner. Every punch, fall, or chase has to make you feel that it costs something. Kashyap's writing ensures that," explains the actor.

Bhat also opens up about the special preparations for the physically demanding character. "Kennedy lives in the body before it reaches the mind. I trained to look a certain way by stretching, going on long walks, and swimming. The insomniac nature of the character demanded me to be sleep-deprived. So, the preparation was about conditioning and not bodybuilding," he says.

Charlie's humour, though dark, adds an interesting layer to the narrative. "I have a great sense of humour. It's dry and sarcastic," claims Sunny. "Other people might think I am not funny, but I know I am. Anurag sir got my sarcasm, and he used it to shape the character of Charlie." Will the brash violence in the movie fail to impress a certain section of the audience? Bhat disagrees. "*Kennedy* is meant to confront the audience. The

violence is disturbing because the world it inhabits is disturbing. If you soften the violence, then you will be dishonest to the story."

Sunny feels the film will benefit from Kashyap's loyalists. "He takes a niche subject and turns it into a cult film." That feels the film is relevant due to its politics. "The subject of moral

Rahul Bhat and Sunny Leone in *Kennedy*.
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Kennedy will stream on Zee5 from February 20